# Simons siblings in conversation

Interviewer: Good evening everyone. Thank you all. This is great to have all of you together. I've been working on some research about why people embrace the Jewishness that they embrace – which might, of course, change over their lifetimes. There are many ways that we could look at you and your Judaism. But today, I'd love to hear about your story, or stories.

The only thing I'll ask is that we try – I don't mind if we all contribute, contradict, challenge each other, reinterpret one another – but let's try not to talk *over* each other so everyone can hear clearly.

Eve: We never do those things [smiling, lightly sarcastic].

Gabrielle: We are so demure [smiling, lightly sarcastic].

Interviewer: The first thing I wanted to start with is where you're all coming from. Was it a shared upbringing? Maybe it was a very different one for all of you? Can you think of an image, a snapshot, a story, a description? Can I get all of your takes on what your upbringing or family home is to you now when you look back on it?

Eve: Do you mean Jewishly or just generally?

Interviewer: Maybe generally and Jewishly. Do you want to start off?

Eve: Sure. So I guess **I feel like the order in which you are in the family of many siblings makes a difference to your perspective**. And so I remember being like **a little mother** a lot as a child to my younger siblings, because like that's what I wanted to do. And that's because I remember when Mia was born. I remember when Jared was born. And so I guess I feel like at times I could have parented as a, like, sibling. And probably was what my siblings might describe as quite bossy. But we also lived in [laughs] – yeah, no-one would say that [laughter] – we also lived in a house that had a big beautiful garden and we – like Mum was home with us a lot when we were little and so when I was young we did lots of cooking and 'arts and crafts' and playing in the garden and being kind of very I guess **organic** is the word that comes to mind? So that's what my childhood feels like.

My parents were really **strict** on me like for my whole childhood, there were lots of **rules** and lots of **boundaries** and that was fine when I was young and not fine when I was a teenager but that was definitely an element of my upbringing, I would say. Yeah.

Interviewer: Jewishly, What was home like?

Eve: Jewishly like I feel like I saw an **evolution** in my parents where they became more religious later on in my life. So when I was young we were kind of Modern Orthodox but more **flexidox** – I don't know. More flexible in the *Orthodoxness* and that kind of changed when I was probably a teenager or even… Yeah, kind of before I moved out of home. So I think that for me Jewishly, had an experience that was less Orthodox than perhaps some other siblings had.

**Commented [User1]:** This transcript is particularly rich as it illustrates **identity formation as a dynamic social performance** rather than a static internal state.

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This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by mapping identity across Macro (Systemic), Relational (Family/Birth Order), and Individual levels.

**Relational-Level (Birth Order/Filtering):** Eve describes her identity as being shaped by her role as the eldest ("a little mother"). Conversely, Jared describes his identity being formed by "watching everyone else," which led to him becoming the "quieter one" to avoid the screaming he observed in his older siblings.

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This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and idiosyncratic labels used by participants to describe the "substance" of their identity.

**"Flexidox":** Eve's term for the family's initial, flexible approach to Orthodoxy.

Mia: It think it changed a lot after Jared was, like, a young kid. Like we've got a farm and watch TV 'cause we were out of Melbourne and like on Shabbat that was the rule and then when Jared came 'round and you started watching TV at home on Shabbes when they were asleep, that for me was like a time where something changed, I think, a lot. And we started to become more, like, less Maccas runs on the way home from the farm. And we wouldn't watch TV on Shabbat at the farm. And that, for me, was when things started to change a lot. I don't know if you'd agree.

Jared: Yeah, I remember that. I remember the changes like it was very quick. We had like lots of arguments about it at the farm. Like, well, should we be doing this at the farm anymore? Should we be taking stuff up to the farm more often, rather than using the cups and the plates that we had there?

Interviewer: So would you say there was a different kind of Jewish-at-home and outside-of-home?

Eve: Yeah, when I was younger, for sure.

Lyla: Yeah, definitely.

Mia: Definitely –

Lyla: But even like in-Melbourne and out-of-Melbourne differences -

Eve: Yeah. But even still then we ate out. we ate out when I was young and that changed when I was like a late teenager.

Interviewer: So that's Kashrut. Can you think of any sort of ways to describe that Judaism?

Lyla: I felt like our home was really, in general, and also from a Jewish perspective was very like homebased. Like, not home… like **home-focused** and I think because Mum didn't have Jewish family and Dad's family wasn't so Jewish and there's not such great relationships with a lot of his siblings that even though we would go to an aunt's on chag, **Shabbes was home**. I remember as a teenager wanting to go out on a Friday night for dinner and was *absolutely* not allowed *ever* 'til I was about 18 until I was allowed out for Shabbat dinner. like **Shabbat was everything**. Family, everyone is there *every* week, *no* exceptions, all chagim. I mean, we had guests and we had friends and would go [to them]. But like that was – when I think about our home, I think about being in our house and being in our garden and Mum and Dad being around, doing craft activities, having people over, having friends over and being very central *in the house*.

Gabrielle: I feel like it was, really… **Judaism was what we did** and I didn't identify as Jewish until much later in life, as who I *was*. A lot of the things that we did at home like creating Shabbat, it was all in – I had this contrast from our family like on Mum's side that aren't Jewish where it's like, oh that's what the *Jews* do and this is the food that the *Jews* eat and like trying to explain all those funny little differences of like – a tallit bag was like a Jewish pencil case and all of the way that we lived our life was Jewish. I didn't feel like it was necessarily something that was *who* we were, it was more of **behavioural-focused**.

Interviewer: Is that because of the constant need to explain it? That translation process?

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This theme identifies "interactional action units"—such as repair sequences and meta-commentary—where siblings act as "truth-checkers" to disrupt individual memory bias or defensive processing.

**The "Evolution" Repair:** Eve begins to describe her parents' religious evolution as occurring when she moved out. Mia and Jared immediately intervene to provide a more granular timeline, citing specific behavioral shifts at their family farm, such as the cessation of "Maccas runs" and the banning of TV on Shabbat.

Gabrielle: Yeah. I think the translation and the contrast between Mum's family who we were very close to – now but also particularly growing up 'cause there were lots of children around us that like weren't *Jewish* kids, but were *family*. I think that contrast really defined it.

Eve: Well I think also because our mum felt the need to not create a division between us and her family. So she made a lot of effort to not separate us which I feel like there's a real concept in Judaism of being separate from others and so Mum like really worked to not do that. So maybe that's part of that kind of identity thing like 'we aren't that different to you, we are the same', as opposed to being – 'we're Jewish, you're not'.

Lyla: I don't really feel like Jewish was something we just *did*. I felt that yeah, we were 'the Jews'.

Jared: That was a part of us.

Lyla: Like that's who we were.

Mia: But that didn't necessarily mean – like the way Mum and Dad have that as a part of how they are now, I think is very different to what it was growing up. We were 'the Jews' –

Gabrielle: As a group.

Mia: As a group of like – I think the way Mum and Dad have really embraced that as - a part of their identity now, I think has happened because we've all had – done that. We've all grown up and we've had to bring Judaism, however it is, into our lives. Almost like with **an active choice** and **because we've done that Mum and Dad have done that**. I don't feel like it was this inherent part – like Mum's become a lot more religious more recently, in the last five, 10 years than they were growing up.

Lyla: I think – a piece of that – when I think of our like **Jewish journey**, I would say even religious like in terms of how much halacha the family was keeping and how much people were investing in Judaism. I think – I don't know if you guys felt this way – that our bat-mitzvahs were really a big piece of that. Then it came time for Mum and Dad to figure out how we're going to do this – for them, for you, for each of us. And **Mum learning with us** for a long time before the bat-mitzvahs, really feeling like it was something we were really choosing to do. That had a big impact on me, on feeling like **this is mine and I own it and I belong to it and I'm choosing to do it**. Bat-mitzvah wasn't really – my parents all the time like it's not about the party, that's the secondary bit. There's no theme, the theme is your bat-mitzvah like that's what you're doing. I don't know if you guys felt that way but I felt like that was a really big piece of – also **bringing Mum and I close in a *Jewish* sense, that shared experience**. Yeah, I don't know, do you guys feel like that? Jared, what was your experience like? Your bar-mitzvah.

Jared: Well it was – I think it was more of as a result of actually kind of what you describe as Mum going and learning with you. Dad felt he had to – I don't know equate that with coming and learning with me, going to my sessions to learn how to layn and how to complete my whole bar-mitzvah. They did have a party for me I think that – I think they were – just because they were more **adjusted**, they were more adjusted to how this bar-mitzvah thing was. And like I think in the Jewish community in Melbourne, it's more of a statement for a bat-mitzvah than a bar-mitzvah. 'Cause a

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**Conferred to Agentic Transition:** Lyla describes her Bat-mitzvah as the point where her parents' religious choices became her own: "This is mine and I own it and I belong to it and I'm choosing to do it". Eve reinforces this, noting that because their parents lacked a religious upbringing, they lived their own "Jewish journey" alongside the children rather than simply imposing one.

Cross-reference: Point continues below (&&)

bar-mitzvah, you're expected to layn. There is no question [like it is with girls] of 'should this girl layn? Should she not? Should she say a speech? Should she not?' Rather, it's expected for a boy to layn. Also I think maybe there was just – Mum and Dad were more **settled** later in life to be maybe – my theory is that they were happy to be more religious, just because they had just grown used to it more rather than when Eve was born because it's the first child so, obviously, there were a lot of questions as to whether they should take this step or take that step. But since they'd had four children, it's just so much easier just naturally just on the fifth.

Gabrielle: I think that's a good point. I wonder if Mum and Dad even knew like *how* to be religious Jews. Like they didn't have anyone to model off and they really only like connected more strongly to the community when *we* were all in school. So I wonder if their growth was really intrinsically connected to ours in some way.

Lyla: Right, but I don't feel like the Jewish*ness* was ever in question. Of like how Jewish our house was. [But more] how *religious*. That's what I felt –

Gabrielle: Yeah, that's true.

Jared: Yeah.

Lyla: But like how Jewish you were, like having Shabbat as a cultural experience – for sure – as religious experience also. But like the Jewish foods, the Jewish celebrations, the Jewish words. Do you know what I'm saying? Like all that **cultural Judaism was never questioned**, it was always there.

Interviewer: From what I'm hearing, Jared being born was the beginning of that process? Or it was around that time? Because of him, inspired him, around that time?

Eve: Well, the family went through a big, like, dynamic shift with - my parents had like a big crisis and a big kind of process around the time that Jared was a tiny baby. Like a change in my parents working and like there was lots of things going on and lots of like hard things happening at that time. So after that, then there was a big family dynamic shift. So it wasn't to do with Jared per se, it just happened to be when he was tiny.

Interviewer: Happened to be [around the same time]?

Eve: Yeah and so then things did change after that.

Gabrielle: Actually, no. I think when Jared was born Dad had this –

Lyla: **Boyness**.

Gabrielle: **- connection to the *legacy* of the Jewish people through you** in a way that I think he didn't have with us before because of the family that *he* came from and like –

Lyla: Like the name and everything.

Gabrielle: The name -

Interviewer: What do you mean by the name?

Lydi: Dad's dad's name.

Jared: My middle name.

Lyla: Simons.

Gabrielle: Your great-grandfather and the grandfather. Like you've got all of the patriarchal names.

Lyla: And his father figure.

Gabrielle: Yeah and –

Mia: You've got **every dead relative in your name**.

Lyla: Yeah, they put four of them on you –

Gabrielle: But [mentions the family surname] also, like -

Interviewer: So you're carrying four generations.

Lyla: No presh.

Jared: Yeah.

Mia: The Simons [name] is also. I think – like Dad, he's very progressive in a lot of ways but he's *so* old-school –

Jared: In a lot of ways.

Mia: - in so many ways and like when it comes to this [gestures] he's a wonderful feminist, because this really strong patriarchalness also in him that carrying on the family name, like *the male,* like I really think you were important to him in that way.

Gabrielle: Well, it ignited something, I think -

Mia: Yeah.

Gabrielle: - In Dad that hadn't - like the way that his mother reacted to you being born and like –

Mia: Yeah, there's was a difference as well.

Gabrielle: Yeah so I think for Dad there was this connection into Judaism, that he could finally come on this journey with Mum that she'd been wanting. And then from there obviously all the stuff that happened. But then afterwards I think it was a real sort of Mum and Dad together on this *religious* journey that they both were connected to.

Jared: That makes sense. I guess Dad was sort of **living his Jewish journey through me** because he didn't have a dad, so he was trying to recreate that with me.

Mia: I think that's also really true.

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**The "Boyness" Correction:** This is the manuscript's primary example of disrupting **identity assimilation**. Jared attempts to frame his father's religious shift as a personal journey through him ("Dad was sort of living his Jewish journey through me"). His sisters provide immediate meta-commentary, revealing the systemic pressure of "Boyness" and the legacy of carrying four generations of patriarchal names.

Cross-reference: Continued from above (**)

Gabrielle: Yeah.

Interviewer: So almost – having children, you specifically but also those milestone events gave them a chance to develop their Jewish journey, which then also had that ripple effect on you at different ages?

Gabrielle: Yeah.

Mia: Mum literally said it two nights ago sitting on my bed. She's – was writing a speech for [Jewish Welfare Organisation], some sort of retreat, whatever it is. And she had to give like a 10-minute *pitch* on what her Judaism means to her. I was talking it through with her 'cause she was really struggling and one of the most common things that she said, it came back to family – like, to us – and really specifically to our bat-mitzvahs. Because they were moments for her of connection. I think that's very true of Mum and that's why Dad had that with you, I think.

Eve: Mum didn't have a Jewish upbringing and Dad didn't have a *religious* upbringing so like they – like you said Jared, they experienced their – like they experienced our upbringing in Judaism – I don't have the words – like they lived what they didn't have through us as well.

Interviewer: Perhaps alongside you?

Eve: Yeah.

Gabrielle: Totally.

Eve: But also actually themselves. 'Cause like my mum hadn't learnt like that before until she learnt with me. And she hadn't had, like, a call-up to the Torah ever, that was never something that – so she actually –

Gabrielle: But hadn't experienced, like, Jewish feminism either.

Eve: She had never exper – yeah, so she did have her own experience of that through us as well.

Interviewer: So maybe there was no single upbringing? It was not only a very different experience for every one of you but that was a dynamic process? It continued to evolve and may still continue to evolve. I'm looking at five people who are not going to say were all marched off the same assembly line.

Lyla: Us? [Mock seriousness] We're the same.

Gabrielle: No, we *are*! Because we're all, like, [laughs] **fierce inquirers** with like things like I feel like Mum and Dad really connected to, to an *intellectual* Judaism and I feel like that that's something that all of us, it – like that **intellectual enquiry** is the same. Anyway, sorry, it's going -

Interviewer: No, that's okay. Where, Jewishly, do you see yourselves now? Is that a kind of sustaining-of-something from your childhood? Or taking something and transforming it into something else? Who wants to go first in terms of thinking about the way you were raised and who you are now?

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This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and idiosyncratic labels used by participants to describe the "substance" of their identity.

**"Fierce Inquirers":** Gabrielle's description of the siblings' shared trait of **intellectual enquiry**.

Lyla: I'll go. There's a few – I'd like to do a few pieces but I don't know that I can answer like fully. The first piece that springs to mind in terms of what we grew up with and what I've done is **Zionism**. That Dad is exceptionally Zionistic, works tirelessly, loving for Israel. That was a part of what his father did and that's something he is – a massive part of his being Jewish. That was something that was very strong in my connection, from a *different* perspective. For me it was much more of a like **religious halachic perspective**. And that's why I chose to live in Israel and to make Aliyah. But when I did Mum cried and guilted me and basically that was not fun. Dad would say I'm really proud of you and this is the dream and this is my father's dream and I am happy that you're doing that. Sort of hearing that and sort of *knowing* that was a special thing for me, in terms of just that piece. So that's like that piece of it for me.

I am **much more religious** than my family is. And in a way that's pretty difficult sometimes. It's not really difficult for like one – there's not one reason why that can be hard. But it just – everyone experiences difficulties in families and that's a piece that can be difficult for me. But **I do feel like it came from home**. Like it came for me, I knew **I wanted to be religious when I was probably about 15 or 16** and I knew **it was going to take a journey for me to get there** and Mum and Dad really facilitated that for me. When I said I want to go to Israel for a year and I want to learn at Lindenbaum, they were like "that's great, you can go there, we'll pay for it." It wasn't ever like "we want you to go on this program, like we want you on that program".

But then, I would rub up against them. When I came back when I really was much more religious, but they wanted me not to insult their family. I didn't want to insult them, but I felt like I could compromise a little less on some things than they felt I could compromise. But it was always – I always felt like that it was fine that I was doing this. I didn't feel like I was rejecting anything from them and I hope they didn't feel like I was rejecting anything from them. I felt like I was able, like, **given permission, if you will, to be this way**. Which I know from a lot of my friends' perspective who've become more religious didn't feel that way in their family homes.

Interviewer: Weren't supported?

Lyla: Yeah or like not as actively parents just embracing that that's who they are right now. It's been my experience that parents kind of like it when their kids are more or less similar to them. And a lot less or a lot more is difficult – it's challenging for them. I never felt like my parents – maybe they didn't find it challenging, they didn't tell me, maybe I've blocked that out, I don't know. But I don't think so. I think that **it definitely began in our home of parents wanting me to take ownership of my Judaism** and feeling that – they felt strongly that it should belong to me, **I felt strongly that it does belong to me and they facilitated that** and that helped me on this journey.

Interviewer: Take you back to Israel-connectedness and that time you said, 15, 16. Do you know what prompted that? Do you know where that came from?

Lyla: Yeah, I do. It came from **my teachers in school**. From Rebbetzin Samuels, I was very close. And from Cara Steyn, and who I was also very close with and still am very close with. I mean **I always liked religiousness but I liked picking up more**, I would say? So there kind of came this point where I was like 'I want to be like that,

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**Identity Optimization:** Lyla describes her move toward becoming more religious at age 15. She clarifies that this was not a rejection of her home, as her parents "facilitated" and "gave permission" for her journey, identifying this as an **optimization of a stable choice** rather than a crisis.

I want to be like them'. I can see that you can be someone who has fun and wears high heels and that's fine and religious so **I want to be that so I think I best start getting there now**. That's where it came from.

Interviewer: So the Israel connectedness?

Lyla: That's probably Bnei [Akiva]'s fault, that's almost for sure Bnei's [Akiva] fault. And my dad. Zionism is very important to Dad and we went to a Zionist school, went to a Zionist youth movement, just talked about it a lot, **I felt very connected to it**. They took us on a big trip when – your bat-mitzvah [pointing to a sibling]. And **I loved it and I felt like very invested in it and just felt like that's where I gotta be**.

Interviewer: Did Bnei come from school or from home?

Lyla: Why we went to Bnei?

Interviewer: Yeah.

Lyla: I don't know. Who started us going to Bnei?

Jared: Eve?

Mia: Who? It's a combination of Mum and Dad being like go, go and probably a lot of our friends. It was a social thing.

Gabrielle: They probably wanted to just, like, sleep!

Eve: I didn't feel like they ever pushed Bnei, honestly.

Lyla: No, they didn't push it.

Eve: I didn't really go and they never pushed it. I think it was social and I didn't really want to hang out –

Lyla: It was probably social, yeah.

Mia: It was totally, it was mostly social.

Jared: Mum and Dad definitely pushed it but strictly for social reasons. I remember sitting on just Friday – sorry, Saturday afternoons and they said just go be with your friends, they didn't say go for any specific reason, just hang out with your friends.

Lyla: They pushed you but they didn't push me. You probably weren't going out with your friends enough.

Jared: I think I was just much more introverted as the – also not just as the youngest kid, as the youngest in the family I was just happy to be quieter, happy to be the quieter one the house. I think as well also where I learnt – I just looked at everyone and just learnt a lot of like stuff from watching everyone else do things. Like I remember just like watching some of you guys just fighting in the house and thinking I don't want to fight with everyone so loudly, why is everyone screaming?

Lyla: We've never fought, no. [Laughing]

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This theme identifies "interactional action units"—such as repair sequences and meta-commentary—where siblings act as "truth-checkers" to disrupt individual memory bias or defensive processing.

**Contradiction on Social Pressure:** Eve claims their parents never pushed them into the youth movement, Bnei Akiva. Jared explicitly contradicts this, noting, "Mum and Dad definitely pushed it but strictly for social reasons," illustrating how siblings force the clarification of narratives.

Eve: So the question is where are you now with Judaism?

Eve: I am now – I find it hard to answer, 'cause I feel like Judaism is measured mostly in religiousness and adherence to halacha, but that to me isn't the only kind of – like that isn't really how I think about myself anymore, even though I used to. So I would say like it's weird for me to say I'm not religious because **I feel like I'm as connected to like the *soul* of Judaism as I ever was, but I just do it differently**. So I would say **I'm not religious but I'm not disconnected.** And I feel like there's an assumption that if you're not religious you're nothing Jewish or you're not very Jewish, or whatever.

Interviewer: But if one believes that there's many ways of being connected, one of which is religiosity and there are many others, then a person could have a whole constellation of different ways that they connect -

Eve: Yes but I think in terms of like our family dynamic and our community from which we were raised in, that's the measure. Like in the Modern Orthodox world, I feel like the measure is how adherent to halacha you appear to be and so it's weird to put myself on the outside of that by saying I'm not religious. *I* know that there's many ways to be Jewish and I know that – some people know that that's like the measure of where we come from, I think.

Interviewer: In your terms.

Eve: Yeah. So – yeah.

Gabrielle: You've had a wild journey with Judaism.

Eve: Yeah, I certainly have. Do you want me to describe that journey? I guess it relates to the upbringing. [Laughs] So I became – like Lyla **I became more religiously observant than what my family was when I was in Israel when I was 18**. And then I also came back from Israel wanting to live in Israel and that was like my plan. Then I got married and that was still my plan and then **I got divorced and then all my plans were off**, temporarily suspended and **I felt like I had to start again**. So then – yeah so **all plans kind of got lost at that point** and I think [pause] **something shifted in my relationship to halachic observance** at that time. But I would still say I was as connected and as religious as I had been, but there was a shift there. It's hard to describe. But gradually across my 20s from like – that shift happened at 23, I went from 23 to say – maybe 26, I was still kind of observant religiously but **gradually like religious Jewish observance was replaced somewhat by, like, meditation and a more – I don't know, a different kind of spiritualty.**

So I took up other practices and let go of Jewish practices, I guess. And then **ended up one day realising like that I wasn't religious anymore and that was a shock.** But yeah, again **I feel like my spirituality is deeply Jewish regardless of my observance.** And **I feel really grateful to my upbringing** 'cause I feel like **I made educated choices about how religious I did or didn't want to be and how Jewish I did and didn't want to be because I was educated.** So I love the fact that **I feel completely comfortable in an Orthodox setting and I know the prayers and I know what to say and I know what happens and it all makes sense to me. And I don't feel I have a place there. I also feel like I can live a life that's uniquely my combination of Jewishness and spirituality.**

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**The "Secondary Crisis":** Eve describes a shift in her 20s where she moved from Orthodoxy to a "different kind of spirituality". She notes she still feels "deeply Jewish" despite lacking halachic observance, illustrating a **refinement of her self-concept** that the manuscript classifies as a secondary crisis.

So I am at the point of like I'm stepping into, soon, having my own family one day and I don't know how to recreate that. **Because how do you – like I'm thinking – how do I give my children what I had but also not be religious?** So if I want to give them Orthodoxy then I have to be Orthodox, so that's really confusing because I don't want to be Orthodox but I want them to feel as comfortable as I feel in an Orthodox setting. So then I think like maybe **I'm hoping my grandparents – the grandparents – will then be able to provide some of that**.

Lyla: Go live next door.

Eve: Or the aunties and uncles. Yeah.

Interviewer: And the silent uncle.

Eve: Silent, watchful uncle. He's not that silent, really –

Gabrielle: Yeah, he's really not.

Jared: I'm not anymore. I was definitely silent as a kid, I was the quietest.

Lyla: Yeah.

Jared: Especially like around the Shabbes table and everyone's like talking about politics and all these things. I was too young to understand half the things you were saying.

Eve: We did dote on you, though, very much so you were not unobserved, although silent.

Mia: I think **in some ways where I am now is totally related to my upbringing and in some ways it has nothing to do with my upbringing**. Like when I was a teenager I wasn't religious at all, didn't believe in God, just didn't really see the point in it, to be honest. It just seemed like a lot of work for nothing. It's probably very naïve look on things. But I really enjoyed – like I think the – almost like the ritualesque things like I enjoyed the community and the family aspect of things. And then **after being sick**, **that to me is what sort of highlighted** – [Pause] how to put into a small amount of time? – **highlighted this particular path to me**. I **think I naturally moved into Modern Orthodoxy because – maybe because that's what I knew? But that's what felt right to me**. That I think has been at times – I think that I've been more religious than Mum and Dad, then also probably very similar to where Mum is I think with her Judaism.

Like I remember Dad is – even though Lyla had done it before me Dad didn't like the fact that I became Shomer Negia, like that I decided to wear skirts, he just didn't really like that. But like I guess I **consider myself Modern Orthodox**. But I think that I still – I do things pretty differently to the way Mum and Dad did even – so I think it sort of **stemmed – a lot of what I do stems from those ideas that were I think instilled in us as kids**. But I think they've changed a lot in how I practise that now.

Interviewer: What like?

Mia: I think in the way that it's much more than just – like I felt like as a kid Judaism was just something – like something we spoke about, Judaism, we were Jewish but it wasn't an inherent part of who I was, or I felt who we were as a family. Whereas

now for me **it's my life and everything I do has something to do with that. My profession, how I think, what I choose to do**. I think the thing that does match really similarly to the way we were raised is **it's not passive, it's not stagnant. There's often a lot of change**. I think the change in our family was over a long period of time, whereas my change is – I think it's three – four years, I think, I've been considering myself religious. There's been a lot of change in how that looks as well. But yeah, I don't know if that answers your question.

Interviewer: I'm interested in life-stage and where you were at when you were unwell. What stage of your life was that? Lyla spoke about 15, 16. Eve spoke about 23, 26, there was a specific period that she was -

Mia: I was 18 when I got sick. I was about – between the year of 19 and 20 was when I started to become religious. Yeah, it was – I **got sick in the middle of my gap-year**. I remember like very distinctly having a conversation a few months beforehand, being very adamant. I don't believe in God. But I remember having conversations, I want to come back and be a Bnei Mad[richa] because that's a fun thing for me to do, not – but I also was very struggling like I don't think I'm going to do it because I'm not religious and I don't want to fake that. Then [pause] yeah, I think the switch, whatever you want to call it, was about early 19 –

Interviewer: Do you know why?

Mia: Yeah, **it really comes down to like one moment when I was in hospital, actually. I think it was like the day that everything kind of came crashing down like denial just suddenly didn't work anymore [pause] and I just totally lost it**, really. I remember – it's a long story – but I remember basically in an incredibly low hysterical moment. The question that kept coming back to my mind was why is God doing this to me? That – so a whole lot of questions but it kind of just circled around that and I think over that next year of my life, it took time to sort of realise what that meant. I think **I just came to the decision that if that was something that in the lowest moment of my life I turned to God, that meant I had to believe in Him. And started a journey of figuring out what that was and why that meant.** It really cultivated in the following year going back to Israel. Which is I think why – one of the reasons – well **part of the reason why I'm very, very Zionist, cultivated going back to the Kotel, to daven, and expecting to be very angry but instead saying thank-you, before I could even realise what words were coming out of my mouth.** So it's sort of that – between those two milestones there was about a year where it just – yeah. I think just thinking about it all and processing it all just made me realise that that's who I am and a part of me. It's a very long story I had to put into a few minutes.

Interviewer: It's pretty powerful.

Mia: Yeah.

Interviewer: Gabrielle?

Gabrielle: It's not a story, it's more [laughter]. **I had a lot of animosity towards Judaism growing up.** I think about it a lot. And I think it comes down to the fact that **it was just something that I *had* to do but didn't really want to.** I have like lots of anecdotes of, like, my auntie's always saying that I used to go to the house and like ask for a ham and cheese sandwich, knowing that it was like the not-kosher thing to have, or crying my eyes out to Dad because my cousins were playing with

something that was mukzeh and like I wanted to play and I wasn't allowed to. It felt like this real hindrance to *life,* for me. I also feel like that **part of my personality growing up was, I just wanted to do the right thing and like please people all the time**, which meant I would just *do* it, 'cause that's what we did.

So in school it was like this whole framework of this life that we were a part of, it was like a Jewish life, a Jewish school and a Jewish youth movement, Jewish friends, Jewish everything. And I feel like I just sort of stood with – like **my Judaism was whoever I was standing with**. So if I was attracted to a really religious guy I would like pretend to be shomer negia for two weeks or something just to, like, be in with them. It became this way of like connecting to people by **chameleoning**. It's not a word but that's how I think of it in my head.

So it wasn't really a *way* of life, it was just this **burdenous** thing. **And I was really angry and didn't like it and didn't enjoy it and didn't find meaning. Also like felt really guilty because I would see like all my family benching at the Shabbes table or just participating in Judaism with joy. And like I didn't have those feelings, at all. And felt like there was – at times I felt like there was something wrong with me, not having the same reaction.** [Pause] So it really just became this superficial thing that I did to make people like me, like being as religious as they were.

And it **really wasn't until I met Kazem that I felt like I had space to consider what Judaism really was.** Because he basically said to me that I'll do whatever you want, I want to spend my life with you. You need to figure this Jewish thing out. If you want me to convert I'll convert, if you want us to be really religious we'll be really religious. If you want to live in Israel, I'll find a way that I can get rid of an Iranian passport [laughs] and get to Israel with you. Yeah, and because of that, I couldn't just copy what he was doing. I couldn't just mirror what he was doing and make him happy by being as religious as him. It was suddenly something that I had to confront independently as well, what does Judaism mean to me and am I Jewish and what does that mean?

**I have a friend who was going through the same process at the same time, which was really helpful, because [pause] there was a sounding board.** And it felt like I had really a safe space to ask my questions and to really consider the situation without offending or upsetting or hurting people because I know that when Mum found out that I was doing things that weren't so religious she was really offended and like took it personally as an attack on her that I wasn't being religious. So I had this, like, removed support group away from the family where I could explore it separately, without being afraid of, like, not upsetting anyone or like not offending anyone in any way.

And **I came to the conclusion that I'm Jewish. And that was a realisation for me that I'd never had before. I'd never felt Jewish and I'd never owned that before or *liked* that I was Jewish.** I felt like I used to hide it when I started university. And I found this - **I found this *peace* with this part of my identity that was so big. Because I could find my own way.** And it – like a lot of it came down to the fact that Amir was, like, whatever you want we will do it, you just have to decide. I can't tell you how to be Jewish, because I have no idea. It gave me the independence and control over this thing that I'd felt like had controlled me for my whole life.

**Commented [User14]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms**
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and idiosyncratic labels used by participants to describe the "substance" of their identity.

**"Chameleoning":** Gabrielle's term for her past behavior of adapting her identity content to match whoever she was standing with to "please people".

So I don't have a religious home and Amir and I aren't creating a religious family. **But we have a Jewish home in the same way that we also have an Iranian home and I don't keep kashrut for Pesach but like there's matza in the house, there's like this symbolic connection to this part of my identity.** I don't keep shabbes but I sure as hell don't go out on Saturdays and like shluf and **keep that essence of the lessons and the values that I can now appreciate from my family and from my upbringing because it's my choice.** It's a lot. [Pause]

Interviewer: To be continued, perhaps. Jared?

Jared: I came last, I'm the youngest.

Gabrielle: It's 'cause you're respectful and kind.

Jared: I just got the boring story. Like I grew up in like a house that – with Mum and Dad figuring out how to, sort of, be parents and therefore they weren't so strict as they were on you, Eve. They had it down pat a bit more, just because they had four kids. And also I feel – also our non-Jewish cousins also understood that we're Jewish and therefore it was so easy to just have that sort of Jewish environment while around them. Although it felt weird at times, it was just so much easier for them because – just because at this stage of the game, they recognised us a bit more as also just, oh it's the sort of separate Jewish crowd just to sort of – oh that's the Jewish part of the family.

Yeah so **it's not like I had a particular struggle ever being Jewish in a Jewish-connected sense. It was more of who am I representing?** Do I want to look like I'm Jewish? Do I want to *act* like I'm Jewish and therefore show people I'm Jewish or show therefore what type of person a Jewish person is? I kind of realised that more and more as I – I don't know, later – I don't know, teen years, I guess. 'Cause as a kid I just – I don't know, I'd ask my dad, oh why don't you wear a kippah to work? He says oh I just – I'm respectful, I don't do that. I never understood that, I always – **I made the decision to always wear a kippah. This year I've decided to take up wearing tzitzit, every day now.** In high school I didn't do it, it was just annoying me, so that's why I just didn't wear them. But **now I've decided I want to look more Jewish and therefore let people understand this is hopefully how a Jewish person is just a regular person, a good person**, right? 'Cause for me, there are a lot of – you know it doesn't matter if you're religious, religious is a separate entity. 'Cause **there's Jewishness and there's Jewish religion**. You hear so many stories about religious Jewish people like in Melbourne like there were molesting cases and there were paedophilic cases that were absolutely horrible and making a horrible name for Jewish people. So I don't want people to think that way, when they think I'm a Jewish person so **I'd rather take up – hopefully take up the mantle without destroying the Jewish name**, rather, making it a decent Jewish name and being okay with it and letting other people be okay with it.

Interviewer: Any particular turning points?

Jared: Turning points? **I don't think there was one point. I just sort of watched things as a kid.** As a younger kid and then becoming an annoying teenager, I just started growing up a bit more. There was no particular stage or time or place that made me say oh yeah, yeah, I could just – one thought – nothing particular came over me. **Maybe while I've been in Israel for seven months now it showed me the ease at which it is to be Jewish there. Jewishness is such a normal thing**

**Commented [User15]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript**
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by mapping identity across Macro (Systemic), Relational (Family/Birth Order), and Individual levels.

**Individual-Level:** Gabrielle traces her current identity peace to meeting her partner, Kazem, which gave her the independence to confront her Judaism as an "active choice" rather than a inherited "burdenous thing". Jared describes his individual choice to wear a kippah and tzitzit as a "mantle" to represent Jewishness positively to the wider world.

Cross-reference: Point continues below (++)

**Commented [User16]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript**
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by mapping identity across Macro (Systemic), Relational (Family/Birth Order), and Individual levels.

**Individual-Level:** Gabrielle traces her current identity peace to meeting her partner, Kazem, which gave her the independence to confront her Judaism as an "active choice" rather than a inherited "burdenous thing". Jared describes his individual choice to wear a kippah and tzitzit as a "mantle" to represent Jewishness positively to the wider world.

Cross-reference: Point continued from above (++)

**there. We walk around and you – so it doesn't matter what you're wearing, what you like, it doesn't matter to people 'cause it's just a country of Jews, so nothing's expected.** Then when we went to Poland for two weeks – sorry for eight days – when we went to Poland I was reminded how weird it is outside of Israel to be Jewish. People were taking photographs of us while we were walking all as a group on Shabbes – well not even on Shabbes, we were just walking around. People were videoing us.

Someone came up to a friend of mine and asked what's these little dangly things? What's this little lid thing on your head? What's that for? So it reminded me of just the oddity it is outside of Israel. It reinforced for me even more so just how important it is people understand and get a good view of what a Jewish person should be.

Interviewer: Do you think the visibility of Orthodoxy, as a male, makes a difference? Is there a difference?

Jared: **Hundred per cent. I've definitely experienced a different experience than my sisters just 'cause I'm a guy.** I had a bris, they didn't. I remember hearing about how **my grandmother saved up all these supplies for the firstborn boy**. 'Cause there aren't many boys in the family. When's there going to be a first boy? She saved up all these supplies and then it just had so many so they had a sort of celebration –

Eve: Mum and Dad found out when I was born, she'd been doing it for all of us if we were a boy and they got really mad at her and they made her throw –

Lyla: They threw.

Eve: They threw with all her stuff, a Simchat Bat for me. 'Cause they only found out about it then.

Lyla: When Mum went into labor, she [grandmother] would go out and get smoked salmon and whiskey in case there was a Shalom Zachar. There wasn't a Shalom Zachar.

Mia: I know Mum and Dad were like well we're going to do something then 'cause they didn't know about it.

Gabrielle: Make sure we'd like not do anything if it was a girl like she would just like put the smoked salmon in the fridge and like eventually drink the whiskey.

Lyla: Can I go back to the visibility thing? That since my experience of being with [my husband] who looks, tzitzit flowing and big kippah, all the time -

Eve: 'Cause you don't look Jewish?

Lyla: **Since I've started wearing a mitpachat, I look more Jewish. But when we were dating, I had no idea how visible being a Jewish male wearing a kippah and especially tzitzit is. And how different it is, his experience like that. It was really quite a shock**, people would talk to us, crazy people would talk to us. We were walking through Flinders Street Station late at night and the busker starts playing Fiddler on The Roof. We were the only people there! That was a great kind of, I love that -

Interviewer: What a Jewish connection.

Eve: [Laughs] Oh my God.

Lyla: There have been times when people have come up to us. Like there was a guy in – on our honeymoon in Noosa, who came up to [my husband] and was like look, I'm also wearing these things. And he had tied tzitzit on his jeans. And he – very Christian, was trying to convert us like in the Bible – that was just weird.

Gabrielle: You've had so many people trying to convert you –

Lyla: Because of how Jewish he looks. That's what I'm saying like I didn't know that and being like walking next to someone who looks so Jewish all the time, you do get far more comments and – like, you can't just like pretend it's not, you know what I'm saying? Like it's –

Eve: I think on that note like women have a choice to –

Lyla: To let people know.

Eve: - look more Jewish or not look more Jewish -

Interviewer: Or express their Jewishness in a much more culturally ambiguous way maybe?

Eve: Yeah, I mean when I put my hair 'cause I did wear – I just wore scarves every day so that was kind of obvious. But I could have chosen to wear a wig and it wouldn't have been obvious, I guess whereas like a guy can't choose anything else that doesn't make it obvious.

Interviewer: He could wear a beanie?

Eve: Yeah, but in the middle of summer, unlikely. Like they have less say over like – yeah, they do, I suppose.

Jared: It's called religious items for guys and maybe just maybe clothing items for girls just because that's how it turns out.

Gabrielle: I also think we don't particularly look like a Jewish woman. You don't necessarily look like a Jewish guy but like with a kippa and tzitzit you are identifiable. 'Cause whenever I would walk with Amir on Shabbes like people would say Shabbat Shalom to us 'cause he looks Middle Eastern. But I never got Shabbat Shalom walking on my own. So like I think it's also – we don't have noses and like –

Lyla: No bumps in our noses?

Interviewer: Distinctive Jewish features?

Eve: Yeah, that's a better way of saying it.

Interviewer: I'm intrigued and I'm touched, there are some pretty powerful stories here and I really deeply appreciate you sharing. I'm wondering now, reflecting on your Jewish education is there, looking back, was that at any stage a significant factor either at the time in leading -

Lyla: Sorry, in school?

Interviewer: School, Jewish education. School. Was that – is that significant today in any way, A, or if it's not is there something – did it set any kind of dominoes in place at any stage? What has Jewish education done?

Gabrielle: I hated it.

Mia: Me too.

Gabrielle: I begged Mum and Dad to send me to Steiner school. Like I hated, hated being in a Jewish school. I still feel so [cringes] -

Interviewer: What was it about school, Gabrielle?

Gabrielle: **I hated the people that I was there with, I hated the teachers that like taught Jewish education and I hated the classes that we had that were Jewish 'cause they were [pauses, sighs] so like boring**. And it was like this really – I had really different teachers to you, Lyla. Like **I didn't have anyone inspiring**. It was like real rote learning and like restrictive, and like filled with all these rules and no explanation and like. Like there was no consideration in my Jewish education for how do we make this meaningful for the Jewish kids? It was just like you have to go to davening, and you have to do this and you have to do that and **it was just restrictive and suppressive and like part of the reason why I hated, *hated* being in and around Judaism.**

Lyla: To be fair you didn't exactly like any part of school.

Gabrielle: [Nodding] I hated school in general.

Interviewer: Not even just exclusively the Jewish thing, it was also that kind of education?

Gabrielle: Like I hated everyone that I was there with and I hated that I had to sit there and be bored in class and I hated like that I had to wear a uniform and like –

Lyla: Go to class.

Gabrielle: I hated that I had – like I was treated like a baby. And I hated like I couldn't just go to the bathroom if I needed to or – like the only time I ever loved school was like I had one teacher that like separated me from the rest of the class and gave me my own work to do and gave me personal attention and like helped my learning through like engaging with me as an individual. I mean I was in the art room and everything else I hated entirely [laughs]. But **I particularly hated the Jewish part 'cause it felt like this thing that I - just like burden that I had to do. It was awful.**

Interviewer: Are you friends with anyone from school?

Gabrielle: Not *really*.

Lyla: Max?

Gabrielle: He's like the one person that was in that support network that sort of like I feel like we 'came out' together.

Mia: You were friends in school.

Gabrielle: We were very, very close in school. But just sort of like if I saw people I'd have a friendly conversation with them but I don't really catch up with them.

Interviewer: I'm just thinking about what everyone's saying so far and four out of five mentioned Israel. Was Israel, any kind of experience in Israel ever a thing [for you]?

Gabrielle: No 'cause it was still that thing that it was like oh everyone loves Israel, so I have to love Israel too. **I never really found that personal connection to it. I didn't want to go away for a year, so I didn't.** The only time I really enjoyed like being in Israel was like when I followed a boy over there and like sort of lived that way which was like this Sephardi arsi lifestyle that was like really different [laughs]. But really fun and we like hung out so much and it was amazing. But **I do sometimes like miss Israel and like miss that way of life and that culture and I miss like the – this *place* but I don't feel connected to it at all from a Jewish perspective. I just feel connected to it as like this is an incredible land to be on. I found it really hard to be there, too.**

Interviewer: Eve? School? Any kind of connection? Ongoing or at some stage?

Eve: **I feel like my Jewish education was pretty poor, pretty poor quality. And I left school with knowledge not because of like classes, but because of more like the informal education I'd say was probably more influential for me. And of like being with Jews and having a Jewish cohort of friends. I had one teacher who I still think about who was influential.** He was an amazing teacher and his classes were fabulous and I still wish I could learn with him. But really only that one person. Apart from that **I felt like I had to start from scratch when I went to Israel, which was pretty disappointing** and pretty silly. But **I had like that background knowledge but I didn't know anything** like I still like – yeah, feel like I left there without much -

Interviewer: What got you to Israel?

Eve: **I went to Hebrew University originally, and then ended up going to midrasha [pauses] kind of in a magical way, 'cause that's obviously where I was meant to go but I was never intending to do any Jewish learning there**, I was just going to university.

Interviewer: But it's Israel, that wasn't the south of France, it wasn't Boston -

Eve: Yeah well **that was really the only option that was supported by my parents**, so they were like we'll pay for you to go to Israel, they weren't going to pay for me to go to The Netherlands. So I guess that's – but I would have – I don't think – I didn't have a strong connection to Israel at that point before I went, but I developed it while I was there.

Interviewer: For you Israel would be – if certain words came to mind? Gabrielle gave us a really interesting snapshot. I'm interested to hear.

Eve: **It definitely feels like my second home, I would say. Yeah, I love going to Israel and I'm kind of sad that I don't want to live there anymore.** I definitely do not want to live there. But like that was a realisation I came to later on, 'cause **I**

**think I can be the best version of myself here, not there. But I kind of am sad about that 'cause I love it there** so yeah, that's how I feel.

Interviewer: You would have been a different person?

Eve: Well I feel like it's just my own personality, that like I'm a person who tends towards anxiety and I had a lot of anxiety in Israel and I had a lot of traumatic experiences in Israel. I was there when lots of things were going on and I feel like I would just be a better person if I'm not in a place that's a war zone and that is a stressful, anxiety-provoking place. I'd just be a better version of Eve if I'm in a place that you don't have to worry about that kind of stuff. [Laughs] So that was something that I realised and I was like oh yeah, that's definitely the case. Oh that's a shame [Laughs] 'cause I'd love to still want to go be there.

Interviewer: Lyla, you spoke about two particularly inspirational teachers. Is there a connection, do you think, between those school experiences and how you see yourself now?

Lyla: Yeah, I definitely would say so. I also like Gabrielle did not enjoy school, any part of school. **I also did not do Jewish studies, just as wrapped up in not liking school.** I guess the same, just being told what to do, not so much a fan. But this funny thing happened. It was in Year 7 we had a really terrible teacher – or in year 8? Some time around then. And **I got kicked out of the top Jewish studies class, got kicked out to like the dumb Jewish studies class. And they had a new teacher who was Rebbetzin Samuel, so it was a little piece of, was meant to be.**

**I also feel like the actual level of Jewish studies was very poor, especially now that I've been studying with Americans and American educators.** Very low-quality Jewish studies. **The role model of these people that I connected to, who I still have a strong connection with, really influenced me.** And I would say that **I had a good Jewish education conceptually, especially with the Rebbetzin who just ignored all curriculum**. And we said, "What's the deal with bad things happening to good people?" She wrote a whole curriculum on that. Then "What's the deal with tzniyut" And she wrote a whole thing about it. And we made our own skirts. And – so I felt like ideas in Judaism, I felt like once I got to Midrasha I was cool with, but technical skills, actual knowledge, what's in the Tanach, like what's Midrash and what's not? Terrible. But then that sort of – i**t didn't bother me 'cause I just didn't want to stop. So I haven't really stopped since.**

Gabrielle: I just want to clarify one of the points that I made if that's okay.

Interviewer: Sure.

Gabrielle: **When I say that I miss Israel it's like I miss it in the same way that I miss Italy, which is still not superficial, it's like a really deep love and appreciation of like a language, a culture, the food, the way of life. Like I love talking to [her nephew, Lyla's son] in Hebrew and like contemplating Israeli food and cuisine. It's like – it's not I miss it because like I'm Jewish. It's I miss it because I loved what that place** was as a place, a part of the world.

Interviewer: How about school, Mia?

Mia: It was the worst. School, like – I mean probably part of it because I wasn't religious and didn't really care about it. I hated it but **I also hated the fact I was in a year**

**of eight girls and 30 guys.** And I hated the fact that like girls just [mutters, unclear]. The school just didn't give a shit like –

Gabrielle: They didn't give a shit.

Mia: They just didn't give a shit about it like it was -

Interviewer: Who? The teachers or students or who?

Mia: Teachers and the school. Like it was just – oh I hated that. And the truth is school's biggest impact – like I wanted to move to [a different, egalitarian school] during school. I just couldn't give a – didn't like it at all. **The biggest impact school had on me is when I went to Nishmat for a few months I realised how pathetic my education was. The biggest influence school has on me now is that I'm an educator because I hated my education.** That's actually the influence it has on me, I just thought it was so bad, and in so many ways. **And that's one of the reason why I think I went into education. It's actually the biggest influence it has on me. I don't credit any of my religiousness to my schooling at all.**

Interviewer: Any of your friends from school, you're still -

Mia: A lot, like a lot of them. Yeah, I mean none of them have a part to play in that either for me, **it was very, a journey I took on my own**.

Lyla: 'Mind if I clarify a few points?

Interviewer: Please.

Lyla: **My role models from school I think were very influential because they stood outside of the school in a way** that will probably –

Gabrielle: They were like not authoritarian and –

Lyla: **Like we'd go and get each other coffee from down the street – It was very not teacher-student relationship**.

Interviewer: They were almost informal ed, weren't they?

Mia: Totally.

Lyla: I still – Cara I'm still super-close with, we talk all the time, I'm teaching her daughter for her wedding. Like it's still a very real friendship, not teacher role. But I don't know if that's like it came from school, but I would say -

Interviewer: It was within the context of school.

Lyla: Yeah but because it shifted –

Mia: It wasn't because of school.

Lyla: - beyond the confines of school.

Interviewer: School was the postcode.

Lyla: Definitely, yeah, definitely credit there.

Interviewer: It's perhaps a little crazy asking you just a few months after graduation, but are you still in contact, do you still have friends from school?

Jared: Fresh out of it, you know. Fresh meat. It's – I also didn't like school for very different reasons that were mentioned before. Like **I didn't like school because I just hated the cookie-cutter environment**. Everyone had to do this, everyone – as Gabrielle said **everyone had to wear a uniform**, everyone had to do this, everyone had to do that. Like also I just saw that quite a lot of my friends in the environment were just very – a lot of them were quite similar to each other in their own ways.

Like we'd sit around in the middle, might have discussion sometimes in a – informal class and **I'd just hear a lot of the same opinion**. And it really annoyed me, it would really, really annoy me. Like as a result I kind of – **I'm closer to my non-religious, less cookie-cutter friends**, I'd say. Maybe just as a result of that. As in **I did enjoy the environment and the ease in which the school provided, just a structure of just learning how to be Jewish in a very basic, basic sense**. As the other girls said the education is poor, the education for just Judaism is very poor there but –

Gabrielle: And you're a guy.

Jared: Yeah and I'm a guy. It – what I'm seeing now is that **the school aimed to tick boxes** and say we are a Modern Orthodox school, we're going to try instil values that seem Modern Orthodox so we're going to put you in a shul twice a day for Shacharit and for Mincha. And we're going to make sure that there's at least one or maybe four out of - four days a week out of the five days of which you will have one class that will be for Jewish studies and that will be about – that could be Gemara, that could be Tanach, that could be anything. But it has to be Jewish, has to be something Jewish. Later – and when I realised that – in Primary I saw – what I saw in Primary was just very basic – maybe 'cause I was just at a very basic mental stage, so I was happy to follow it along.

**In high school, I was having more questions, I was having more thoughts, more challenges to what they were *feeding* me. I really didn't like that I was just getting back these very basic answers** that were just trying to keep me in the form of what the school was trying to create by – in an ex-collegian. Just try to create this person. I just didn't want to – I didn't want to act like. I just wanted to go through school and figure out stuff. But the school was just providing this other system of just making this very basic, very strict form of a person.

I just wanted to like add to one of your other questions about going to Israel. **I don't think like my school, like my youth movement, actually got me to Israel. I think it was my parents, heavily, because like Mum and Dad**, they said a lot, a lot, a lot in my final year of school and the year before. You're going – **if you want to go away for a year it's going to be Israel, has to be Israel because that's the only thing we'll fund and we'll help you out with**. Also it's just a great environment and we wish we would have both have gone. I realised – I think that maybe at one stage my dad might have actually moved to Israel if he hadn't have met Mum. He actually might have made aliyah, I think 'cause he's so pro it, he's so all for it and he's so happy that Lyla's made Aliyah. He's so like happy that I'm living in Israel this year, come back for a week to see everyone and going back again. So I think yeah, my drive to go to Israel was definitely from Mum and Dad.

**Commented [User17]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms**
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and idiosyncratic labels used by participants to describe the "substance" of their identity.

**"Cookie-Cutter Environment":** Jared's metaphor for the uniform, box-ticking nature of his school experience.

Eve: Have we broken your hypothesis yet?

Interviewer: I didn't come into this with hypotheses. It's beautifully qualitative. There's just one word that maybe I missed but I don't think came up. Family loomed big. There's one word I haven't heard and am keen for you to react to it, please. Jewish community. To what extent has, was, is that a part of the way you do Jewish?

Lyla: I think it's hard for – jumping in, sorry – growing up, **the Jewish community sort of was an extended family to an extent**. Meaning like we didn't have a lot of Jewish family that we did a lot of things with. So **on the chagim there were sort of lot of the same families that we did things with**. And I don't know if that qualifies as community or friendship. Like we've always had the same family at – we always go to the same family for second-night Seder. We always go to the same family for Pesach. There's like this group of families of doing a lot of things together. So – and when all – like when there's been times like a baby, Sheva Brachot, all this kind of things – these groups of families are there in our lives like there in our life-cycle events. I don't know if that's really what you mean by community as opposed to like shul and – 'cause **shul is different for every single one of us. Is that right? Even Mum and Dad? Like each of us goes to a different shul.**

Mia: We're in the same –

Lyla: We're in the same schul.

Mia: For now.

Lyla: But in terms of – **I always felt a part of the Jewish community and I always felt a part of** [Modern Orthodox synagogue] **and Bnei Akiva.** [Modern Orthodox synagogue] has pretty bad reputation for like welcoming, but I never felt unwelcomed or judged or maybe I just – I'm just like a person that doesn't love it so much. But **that has been a really – always a part of my life and especially since coming back from Israel, especially my time with [husband], has been – the Beit Midrash has been a really, really fundamental - that is a place I *truly* feel at home, I love being there. I was there like every night when I got back from Israel until – basically 'til we left. And that time we wanted to have the Brit there. That's a place that has been really, really strong for me, for us in terms of both finding friends there and knowing that that's a place where we can go, the place where we feel comfortable to be ourselves**. Yeah.

Interviewer: There's lots of different ways people can express a connection to community. There's volunteerism and that would include teaching. Community connectedness could be philanthropy, it could be social, cultural events, museums, Jewish book clubs. There's lots of ways people do community connectedness and some with investment of time, money, that sort of thing. Could anyone speak to that? -

Eve: Yeah, I feel like Mum and Dad never really fit into a community and so that's why it's like – I feel like that's part of why **it doesn't come up because it wasn't defining of us as growing up. We didn't identify with a community and I feel like that's still possibly somewhat of a case** for – because Mum and Dad religiously identified differently to, like, the [Modern Orthodox synagogue] community. And I guess also because like that coming back to that idea of my mum not wanting to separate out her family from her like sibling family. So **our extended family was our community, our cousins we spent a lot of time with growing up and still do. So that was also part of our community. And so the Jewish**

**community wasn't our only community**, I guess and it wasn't our only identification for community.

So yeah, I feel like we were always different to *the* community which was the [Modern Orthodox synagogue] community. And so that's part of the nonidentification with it and I feel like none of us like really – I don't know, maybe you feel differently now but I guess the religious community is how we would connect or disconnect and I don't think many of us really felt deeply aligned with whatever that community was. Maybe I'm wrong, maybe people did at times on that, maybe –

Mia: Even when I did. I think my connection, especially [Modern Orthodox synagogue] has been Bnei. But to be honest I really – **as much as I feel like [Modern Orthodox synagogue] is my community I also felt a huge rejection from it. I think that a lot of that came down to being I feel, a strong, independent woman**, I really feel had a lot to do with that. I went for [a senior leadership position] in Bnei. I didn't get it, to someone who was so obviously not liked and qualified. For me that was the beginning of what I think started me feeling really rejected by community, even though I am a part of it and I think it would consider me a part of it. I have this like weird like **I love it and I absolutely hate it at the same time**. So like I – yeah, I also agree like I think that in theory we were totally – should have been one of the [Modern Orthodox synagogue] families growing up like we were friends with all of the [Modern Orthodox synagogue] families and we spent all our shabatot with them. But **I don't ever feel like we were really considered one of them, growing up**. Maybe that's just me. So like it's always been there and it's always been a part of – I've given a lot to it and there are parts of it that I love and I really feel strongly connected to it. And I also really like feel rejected by it at the same time. I don't know, it's a weird way to – yeah, I don't know if it makes any sense.

Gabrielle: It's not weird, it's how you feel.

Jared: Makes sense. It's just geographically we're just located in a more Jewish – sorry, the religious Jewish community area. We all live like seconds away from the Chabad area and the Adass [hareidi] area. And we're like a 10-minute walk up the road from [Modern Orthodox synagogue]. So it makes sense that we I guess be – at least I felt that we were closest to [Modern Orthodox synagogue] community just because of where we lay. Also I think – maybe we just didn't connect 'cause sadly our just – our community, this [Modern Orthodox synagogue] community just isn't – for me isn't that great that we would – great. Whereas 'cause a lot of – I don't know, as people have said like we didn't – yeah, we didn't fall into that community thing. But also there's just – we say that but also a lot of my friends have told me that thousands of times. That **we just do not fit into that, we don't fit into that community sense**. But as – I don't know as I'm older, I kind of realise there's a lot more communities in Melbourne. I realise there's a very big Jewish community as a whole in Melbourne. But it's just sadly we just – just in this one it's not – maybe not that great. There are other ones that I think Eve has definitely identified with, like one other one, that's very – I think it's very great, it's very lovely.

Eve: [Jewish humanist congregation]?

Jared: Yeah, [Jewish humanist congregation]. It's a very lovely community as in it's not exactly – I don't know if it's exactly my values. But it's a very – it's got great values,

**Commented [User18]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript**
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by mapping identity across Macro (Systemic), Relational (Family/Birth Order), and Individual levels.

**Macro-Level (Systemic Filtering):** The siblings discuss their detachment from the institutional community. Eve traces this to their mother's experience as a convert who "wasn't openly embraced," noting that she "passed that across to us, this sense of de-identification".

Cross-reference: Continued below (&&)

very beautiful. When you stood up for that speech that you gave it was – showed me how welcoming they were, show me how like grateful they were that you could connect and that everyone could connect to each other.

Eve: That's true.

Interviewer: Drawing to a close, any postscripts? Any things that bubble up to the surface?

Lyla: I'm trying to think of like community things that I'm involved in like if we were ever choosing a charity or anything it was like choose Israel. Like do you know what I'm saying? Like it seems to us that community's very shul-based. It wasn't – like the Holocaust museum and they said there's not enough money to volunteer. But like there was a lot of like broader community volunteering, like we volunteered at Sacred Heart and like – you know what I'm saying? Like – yeah, I don't know, it's more like tribe like people, the community.

Gabrielle: Well **a sense of civic service I think is a value that like all of our extended family have on both sides**. If you could think of our grandparents and how much philanthropic support and how many people they've helped and how much they've done for like the world, that we don't even know about. **There's this like passed-through-the-generations sense of like helping people from an individual perspective**, not as this is my duty to a community that uphold and like keep the constructs of a community together.

Interviewer: So noninstitutional support?

Gabrielle: Completely like **lone wolf. I'm just going to help because I know that I can and it's the right thing to do**.

Lyla: Every little bit you do.

Gabrielle: Yeah from like –

Lyla: All those little bits.

Gabrielle: Yes like real 'power of the individual'. In however that can translate for you in your life like a lot of our family members are working in civic service, whether it's education, midwifery, all of our cousins as well like everyone is helping in a really non-constructed, isolated way that comes from the heart. I think like the concept of the Jewish community, there's like this thing that's like reinforced so that people – there's like politics and power and control and like all of this stuff. And then there's also all of the amazing individual stuff that you were talking about which is like the connection to family and home and love that's like [pause] really separate in my mind to like buying your seat in shul versus taking food to someone who's just had a baby like they're really -

Interviewer: But that's – taking food to someone is community, it's just not institutional.

Gabrielle: Yeah well it's like – maybe **it's like backstage [vs.] front-of-house**, sort of thing? Like that separation in my mind where it's – like it's private and it's anonymous and it's sort of the help of humanity in general. Because most of the people that we grew up with know only Jews, then it stays within the people that you know. Yeah, that's my interpretation.

**Commented [User19]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms**
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and idiosyncratic labels used by participants to describe the "substance" of their identity.

**"Back Stage [vs.] Front-of-House":** Gabrielle's metaphor to distinguish between private, anonymous acts of service and institutionalised community politics.

Jared: There was also sport. We all did – were you in Maccabi as well, Eve?

Eve: Yeah.

Jared: We all were in sport, all in the same Jewish club. I mean like I say I went to like another Jewish club in like footy. But **everyone went to a Jewish club for sport. So we had also that additive that just also just kept us connected whilst also not being like directly in the centre of everything. It's just that extra layer that added on**, I think. Also another thing that really like built up the community as a whole is just the fact that it's a – there's a lot of Holocaust survivors in the Melbourne Jewish community. So there's more of an emphasis as a whole by people. Not sure if it directly correlates to us as a family 'cause we didn't have anyone direct -

Interviewer: Melbourne has been called a Holocaust community as well as community where there are people who are holocaust survivors. For some, there may have been some kind of effect, growing up with Holocaust survivor relatives, whereas for others there may have been a kind of halo effect.

Jared: I think personally because **we had a relative who was in the Holocaust that definitely – it gave me a subtle impact of how it just felt like an extra need to be Jewish**, I think. Especially just 'cause I've been to Poland this year. And I've seen what happens when – maybe a lack of I think unity, maybe it's something else – but when your enemy groups you to be Jewish rather than the actual Jewish people are connected with. Rather, I find – I don't know, maybe Jews segregate themselves rather than unify and our enemies unify us just because we're fighting a common enemy which is what we sometimes don't always see in each other.

Eve: I think it's really fascinating that you've brought that up about community because I think we've all been part of the Jewish community quite extensively to varying degrees within our personal life. As a family as well. **It's fascinating that we don't identify very strongly with that community as much as we're a part of it**. **I feel like it also comes from our mum who didn't feel accepted by the community as a convert. I feel like she de-identified herself with the community because she wasn't openly embraced and I feel like she's passed that across to us, this sense of deidentification** to some extent which is really interesting. [laughs]

Mia: One thing I just – I don't know, it's not exactly directly relevant to this but I just was thinking about it and **all of our stories are just so different**. In the one common thing is **Mum and Dad really raised us all as being independently thinking, strong people** and that is so –it's the same in all of us. They might not have always liked the way that that has translated. [Laughter] A little bit it's like well – it's like when Mum doesn't like that we're super-Zionist. Well you raised us that way! This is – this is kind of how it is. Even - like **the common thread in all of us and why we've taken the paths we have is because we were encouraged to think for ourselves. It's just taken different paths but it was because of that 'cause we're all different people**. I just think about it, I just wanted to say that.

Eve: That's true.

Interviewer: Thank you.

Eve: Thank you.

END OF INTERVIEW

**Commented [User20]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript**
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by mapping identity across Macro (Systemic), Relational (Family/Birth Order), and Individual levels.

**Macro-Level (Systemic Filtering):** The siblings discuss their detachment from the institutional community. Eve traces this to their mother's experience as a convert who "wasn't openly embraced," noting that she "passed that across to us, this sense of de-identification".

Cross-reference: Continued from above (&&)